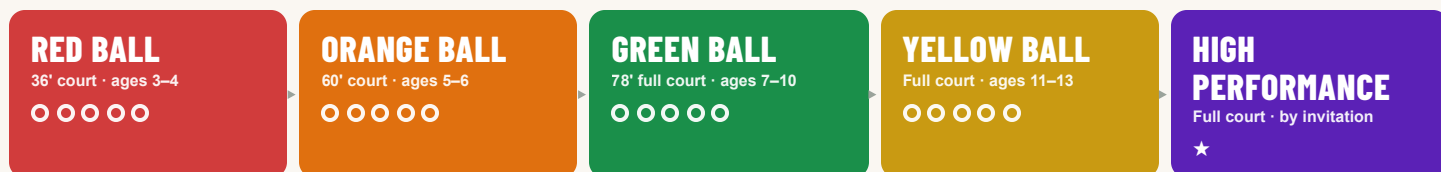


THE STRINGS EXAM.

Every test, at every ball color, in one place. **Four colors, five strings per color, three pass/fail tests per string — 60 tests total.** One page per color: run the test exactly as written, judge it against the pass bar exactly as written, and every kid at Sleepy Hollow is measured against the same standard by whichever coach is on court. Clear string 5 and the player is **promoted, announced by name.**



5 strings per color • 3 tests per string • **string 5 is the promotion test** • Yellow 5 earns the High Performance invite

— HOW TEST DAY RUNS

- 1 **First class of the month:** post the month's tests on the fence. Nothing is hidden — the tests *are* the curriculum.
- 2 **All month:** train toward them. A kid who can't tap 10 in a row on week one should be tapping 10 by week four.
- 3 **Last class of the month = Test Day.** Parents are invited to stay for the final 15 minutes. Run each test as written on the color page.
- 4 **Mark the score sheet** (last page) as you go — name, color, string, which of the 3 tests passed. Hand it to Darrin; he enters it in ClubMode.
- 5 **The band moment:** all 3 tests passed = call the player to the net, say the string out loud in front of everyone, and tie the band on their racquet.

— JUDGING

Read the PASS line, not your gut. If it says 5 of 8, it's 5 of 8 — for the naturally gifted kid and for the one who's fighting for it.

Partial credit is real. Passing 2 of 3 tests banks those two forever. Next month the player only retests what's left.

Not everyone passes, and that's the product. A string that can't be failed is a participation trophy and the kids know it.

When it's a coin flip, retest. A kid who scrapes through on a technicality doesn't believe the band means anything either — and the one who earns it next month believes in it for good.

— HOUSE RULES

Test Day is the last class of every month — parents are invited to stay for the final 15 minutes.

To test, a player must have attended 3 of the month's 4 classes.

To test, a player must be registered for the next month.

Not everyone passes — and that is the point. Passed tests are banked; retest only what is left next month.

— HOW TO READ A TEST

THE STANDARD 1 5 of 8 hand-fed forehands land in the red court

MEASURES

Clean contact out front on the forehand side with a low-to-high swing.

RUN IT

Coach kneels near the net post and hand-feeds 8 gentle bounces to the player's forehand from about 10 feet. Player hits into the 36-foot court.

PASS BAR

5 of the 8 land in. Contact must be a swing, not a push — a caught-and-shoveled motion does not count even if it lands in.

All 60 tests on the next four pages carry the standard, the run and the pass bar, written exactly this way — the MEASURES line lives on the website, where there's room for it. **The pass bar is the line — don't move it.**

The whole ladder lives online too. Every test, every color, no login needed — send it to any parent who asks.

club.coachmode.ai/pathway/curriculum

TOP OF THE LADDER

A club hoodie with your rank on the sleeve • Your name on the board in the pro shop • A match against the Director of Tennis

RED BALL

36' COURT • RED BALL • AGES 3–4

5 STRINGS / 15 TESTS



Where every player starts. Tests here are about effort and habits — nobody has to win anything yet.

1 RACQUET CONTROL

1 10 consecutive taps up on the strings, and 10 dribbles down

RUN IT Player stands still with their own racquet and one red ball. Coach counts out loud. Taps up first, then dribbles down to the ground. One restart is allowed per direction.

PASS BAR 10 in a row up AND 10 in a row down, feet roughly planted. Walking three steps to chase the ball is a miss — reset and try again.

2 Hold ready position and split step on command, 5 times in a row

RUN IT Coach faces the player and calls 'SPLIT!' five times at uneven intervals while the player holds ready position. Watch the feet: both should leave the ground a little and land wide.

PASS BAR All 5 splits land on time, wide, and balanced. Flat-footed or late twice is a retest.

3 Net to baseline and back without dropping the racquet

RUN IT Player starts at the net holding the racquet in ready carry, runs to the baseline, touches it with the racquet head, and returns. Nothing is timed — this is about control, not speed.

PASS BAR Complete the round trip with the racquet under control the whole way. A dropped racquet is a simple do-over — up to two tries.

2 CONTACT

1 5 of 8 hand-fed forehands land in the red court

RUN IT Coach kneels near the net post and hand-feeds 8 gentle bounces to the player's forehand from about 10 feet. Player hits into the 36-foot court.

PASS BAR 5 of the 8 land in. Contact must be a swing, not a push — a caught-and-shoveled motion does not count even if it lands in.

2 5 of 8 hand-fed backhands land in the red court (two hands is fine)

RUN IT Identical setup to the forehand test: 8 hand feeds to the backhand side, coach kneeling at the net post.

PASS BAR 5 of 8 in the court. Watch for the player sneaking around to hit a forehand — a run-around is a miss for that feed.

3 Finish every swing low-to-high, racquet up by the shoulder

RUN IT Judged across the 16 feeds of the two tests above, not as a separate drill. Coach watches the finish position on every swing.

PASS BAR The finish ends up by the opposite shoulder on clearly most swings. Chopping down or stopping at the hip on half the feeds is a retest.

3 RALLY

1 6-ball cooperative rally with a coach over the net

RUN IT Coach stands on the other side of the 36-foot net and rallies WITH the player, keeping feeds easy. Count out loud. Coach errors do not reset the count.

PASS BAR 6 player-hits in a row without the player missing. Three attempts allowed — it's a rally test, not a pressure test.

2 Track the ball and let one bounce happen without swinging early

RUN IT During the rally test (or 6 extra feeds), coach watches timing: does the player wait for the bounce and hit at the top, or lunge at the ball in the air?

PASS BAR Waits for one bounce and swings on time on at least 5 of 6 balls. Swinging before the bounce twice is a retest.

3 Say which side is forehand and which is backhand without being told

RUN IT Coach holds a ball to one side, then the other, and asks 'what shot is this?' Four times in mixed order.

PASS BAR 4 of 4 named correctly. Hesitation is fine; guessing is not.

4 SERVE & SCORE

1 3 of 5 underhand serves land in a service box

RUN IT Player serves underhand from the 36-foot baseline, standing wherever they are comfortable. Coach points at the box to aim for, then steps out of the way. Five attempts, no rush.

PASS BAR 3 of 5 land in a service box. At Red Ball the WRONG box still counts — getting the ball over the net and in, unaided, is the whole skill here.

2 Count the score out loud through a first-to-5 game — 1, 2, 3, 4, 5

RUN IT Coach and player play a quick first-to-5 game off coach feeds. After every single point the coach asks "what's the score?" and the player answers out loud.

PASS BAR Calls the running score correctly after at least 4 of the 5 points and says who won at the end. Counting on fingers is completely fine.

3 Call your own ball in or out — and mean it

RUN IT During point play, coach deliberately lands two balls near lines and asks the player to make the call out loud with a hand signal.

PASS BAR Makes a clear, out-loud call both times. Whether the call is RIGHT does not matter at Red Ball — hesitating, looking at a grown-up, or refusing to call does. One coaching moment is allowed, then a retest ball.

5 PLAY

PROMOTION TEST

1 Play 3 points start to finish, each starting with an underhand serve

RUN IT Player plays 3 points with the coach as the other player. The coach keeps every ball easy and rescues the rally when needed. If the serve misses twice, the coach drops a ball in and the point is played anyway — it still counts.

PASS BAR All 3 points get started by the player and played to a finish. Winning is NOT required at Red Ball, and neither is a serve that lands in: two attempts, then the coach feeds. This is not a service game.

2 Play a first-to-5 mini game against a friend — and finish it, win or lose

RUN IT Two players play first-to-5 points. Coach stands with them, feeds the ball in when serves break down, and helps count the score out loud.

PASS BAR The game reaches 5 with the player trying on every point. Win or lose does not matter one bit — quitting, wandering off, or melting down is the only way to miss.

3 Shake hands and say who won at the end

RUN IT Observed at the end of the mini game: does the player come to the net, shake hands, and say who won without being told?

PASS BAR Does it unprompted, happily, win or lose. Being reminded once means a retest at the next game.

WHEN STRING 5 IS CLEARED

Moves up to **Orange Ball** — 60' court, orange ball — announced by name in front of the whole class.

COACH NOTES — who is close, who has a retest waiting

ORANGE BALL

60' COURT • ORANGE BALL • AGES 5–6

5 STRINGS / 15 TESTS



The court grows to 60 feet. Tests stay friendly — real skills, coach right there.

1 FOOTWORK

1 Split step on 8 of 10 feeds — unprompted

RUN IT Coach feeds 10 balls at rally pace, alternating sides, and watches only the feet. No reminders once the drill starts.

PASS BAR 8 of 10 balls have a visible split step timed to the coach's contact. Reminded split steps do not count toward the eight.

2 Recover to the middle after 5 consecutive shots without being reminded

RUN IT A 5-ball side-to-side feed. After each hit the player must cross the center hash before the next feed comes.

PASS BAR All 5 recoveries happen unprompted. One verbal reminder from the coach fails the attempt; run it again.

3 Side-shuffle the ladder without crossing the feet

RUN IT Two passes through an agility ladder (or a line of 8 spots), shuffling sideways, racquet held in ready carry.

PASS BAR Both passes clean: feet never cross, hips stay low, head stays level.

2 GROUNDSTROKE SHAPE

1 6 of 10 forehands land past the service line, full finish over the shoulder

RUN IT Coach feeds 10 medium-pace balls to the forehand from the opposite baseline. Cones mark the service line.

PASS BAR 6 of 10 land beyond the service line AND carry a full over-the-shoulder finish. A deep ball with a chopped finish is a miss.

2 5 of 10 backhands the same

RUN IT Identical to the forehand test: 10 feeds to the backhand, same target.

PASS BAR 5 of 10 deep with a full finish. Two-handed is expected at this level.

3 Show a unit turn before the ball bounces

RUN IT Judged during the 20 feeds above: at each bounce, had the player already turned?

PASS BAR Turned before the bounce on roughly 8 of 10 balls. Late prep on half the feeds is a retest.

3 RALLY

1 10-ball rally with a coach on the 60' court, no feed reset

RUN IT Coach rallies cooperatively from the opposite baseline, counting player hits out loud. If the coach misses, the count stands and the rally restarts at the same number.

PASS BAR 10 player-hits in one unbroken run (coach errors excluded). Three attempts.

2 6 balls in a row on the backhand wing alone

RUN IT Cooperative rally where the coach plays every ball to the backhand half. Player must answer with backhands.

PASS BAR 6 consecutive backhands in play. A run-around forehand resets the count.

3 Keep the rally alive after being pulled wide once

RUN IT Mid-rally, coach deliberately pulls the player wide once, then continues the rally. Run it three times.

PASS BAR On at least 2 of 3, the wide ball comes back in play AND the player recovers to continue the rally at least two more shots.

4 SERVE

1 Overhand motion — trophy position, then drive up to the ball

RUN IT Player hits 6 serves while the coach watches only the motion: down-together-up-together, a held trophy shape, contact above the head.

PASS BAR A clear trophy position and upward drive on at least 5 of 6 swings, regardless of where the ball lands.

2 4 of 8 serves into the correct box from the orange baseline

RUN IT 8 overhand serves from the 60-foot baseline, alternating deuce and ad the way a real match does. Coach stays quiet — the player works out which box is theirs.

PASS BAR 4 of 8 in the correct diagonal box. Underhand does not count at this level.

3 A second serve that goes in when the first one misses

RUN IT Coach announces 'second serve' before each ball. Player hits 5 of them; any safe motion is allowed — slower swing, higher net clearance.

PASS BAR 3 of 5 second serves land in. The point is a repeatable safe serve, not pace.

5 COMPETE

PROMOTION TEST

1 Play a first-to-7 mini match against a friend, calling the score out loud

RUN IT Two players play first-to-7 points, alternating serves every 2 points. The coach stands courtside, helps untangle score disputes, but does not play.

PASS BAR The match reaches 7 with the player announcing the score before most points. Winning is not required — running a real scoreboard is.

2 Win 2 of 3 points at the net after an approach shot

RUN IT Coach feeds a short ball; player approaches, then plays out the point against the coach, who hits soft, catchable passes right at the player. Run 3 points.

PASS BAR Win 2 of the 3 net points. The coach is feeding wins here — staying on the baseline after the short ball is the only real way to miss.

3 Run the between-point jobs yourself — balls, sides, and the score out loud

RUN IT Observed during the mini match above: does the player collect balls, go to the right side, and announce the score without being steered? Afterwards the coach asks them to recite the real scoring ladder.

PASS BAR At most one reminder across the whole match, AND the 0-15-30-40-game ladder recited in order. Two or more reminders means a retest next month — this one comes fast with a month of practice.

WHEN STRING 5 IS CLEARED

Moves up to **Green Ball** — the full 78' court for the first time — announced by name in front of the whole class.

COACH NOTES — who is close, who has a retest waiting

GREEN BALL

78' FULL COURT • GREEN-DOT BALL • AGES 7–10

5 STRINGS / 15 TESTS



Full court for the first time — and the first tests you have to win.

1 CONSISTENCY

1 15-ball cross-court rally with a partner, full court

RUN IT Two players rally cross-court on the full court. Coach counts the tested player's hits out loud.

PASS BAR 15 hits by the tested player in one run. Coach may substitute as partner if the peer cannot sustain it. Three attempts.

2 10 of those on the backhand side

RUN IT Same setup, backhand cross-court only.

PASS BAR 10 backhands in play in one run. Run-arounds reset the count.

3 No ball into the net on the second bounce for the whole drill

RUN IT Judged across both rally tests above. Coach tracks every player error: net, or past the lines?

PASS BAR Zero net errors across one complete successful run of each rally. Net errors during failed runs are fine — the standard applies to the passing runs.

2 DIRECTION

1 7 of 10 balls into a target zone cross-court

RUN IT Coach marks a cross-court target zone (service box plus six feet) with cones and feeds 10 rally-pace balls.

PASS BAR 7 of 10 into the zone. Balls in play but outside the zone are misses.

2 Change direction down the line on call, 5 of 10

RUN IT Cross-court rally feed; when the coach calls "LINE!", the player redirects that ball down the line. Called 10 times total.

PASS BAR 5 of 10 called balls land in the down-the-line half. Redirecting without the call means the player is not listening — those do not count.

3 3 in a row deep past the service line on demand

RUN IT Coach announces 'depth test now' mid-feed and counts the next balls.

PASS BAR 3 consecutive balls past the service line, within the first two times it is called.

3 SERVE & RETURN

1 5 of 10 first serves in with a full motion from the full-court baseline

RUN IT 10 first serves, alternating boxes, full overhand motion required.

PASS BAR 5 of 10 in. The motion must include a trophy and full extension — pushed serves do not count.

2 6 of 10 returns land past the service line

RUN IT Coach (or a strong peer) hits 10 medium-pace serves; player returns from a proper return position.

PASS BAR 6 of 10 returns in play AND past the service line.

3 Second serve in play 8 of 10 times

RUN IT 10 second serves, alternating boxes, each one announced as 'second serve' to add weight.

PASS BAR 8 of 10 in the correct box. This is the most important serving stat in junior tennis — the bar is high on purpose.

4 NET GAME

1 10 consecutive volleys — 5 forehand, 5 backhand — from the service line

RUN IT Coach feeds from the opposite baseline, alternating sides; player volleys from the service line.

PASS BAR 10 in a row in play, 5 each side. A full-backswing volley gets one warning, then counts as a miss even if it lands in.

2 Put away 3 of 5 overheads

RUN IT Coach throws or hits 5 medium lobbs from the net; player starts at the service line.

PASS BAR 3 of 5 overheads land in with authority — bouncing over the coach's head or clearly unreturnable.

3 Approach, split, volley — the whole sequence, 4 of 6

RUN IT Coach feeds a short ball; player approaches down the line, splits as the coach hits a pass, and volleys. Run 6 sequences.

PASS BAR 4 of 6 sequences end with the first volley in play. Missing the split step fails the sequence even if the volley lands.

5 MATCH PLAY

PROMOTION TEST

1 Win a set to 4 against a peer, serving, self-scored, no coach

RUN IT First to 4 games (no-ad is fine) against a peer within one string of the player. Fully self-officiated.

PASS BAR Win one such set. Attempts can run in class all month and bank when won.

2 Play one full club or Junior Team Tennis match

RUN IT Any club ladder match, JTT match, or in-house tournament match, verified by the coach or director.

PASS BAR Complete the match. The result is irrelevant.

3 Call every line honestly for a whole set

RUN IT Observed during the set-to-4 above. Coach silently tracks every close call.

PASS BAR No hooked calls, no forgotten scores; disputes settled by replaying the point. One bad-faith call fails the test — honesty is the whole point.

WHEN STRING 5 IS CLEARED

Moves up to **Yellow Ball** — full court, real ball, real matches — announced by name in front of the whole class.

COACH NOTES — who is close, who has a retest waiting

YELLOW BALL

FULL COURT • YELLOW BALL • AGES 11–13

5 STRINGS / 15 TESTS



The real thing. Full court, yellow ball, real matches, real standards.

1 RALLY UNDER PRESSURE

1 20-ball cross-court rally with a partner, no errors

RUN IT Two players rally cross-court at genuine rally pace — not moonballs, not blasting. Coach counts the tested player's hits.

PASS BAR 20 hits in one unbroken run. The coach can stand in as partner if peers cannot hold up their end. Three attempts.

2 10-ball down-the-line rally

RUN IT Both players rally down the line on one half of the court.

PASS BAR 10 player-hits in one run down the line.

3 Hold the rally after being pulled off the court twice

RUN IT Coach rallies, deliberately pulling the player wide twice within one rally, then continuing. Run three rallies.

PASS BAR On 2 of 3 rallies, both defensive balls come back AND the rally continues at least two more shots after the second one.

2 SERVE

1 6 of 10 first serves in with real pace

RUN IT 10 first serves, alternating boxes. Coach judges pace honestly: would this serve trouble a peer returner?

PASS BAR 6 of 10 in with committed pace. Ten dinks in a row scores zero.

2 8 of 10 second serves in with spin — kick or slice, your choice

RUN IT 10 second serves; coach watches for genuine spin: the ball curves or kicks, the racquet path brushes up or around it.

PASS BAR 8 of 10 in the box WITH visible spin. Flat pushed serves that land in do not count.

3 Serve to the corner that is called, 4 of 6

RUN IT Coach calls 'T', 'body', or 'wide' before each of 6 serves, mixed order, both boxes.

PASS BAR 4 of 6 land in the called third of the box.

3 PATTERNS

1 Serve +1: serve wide, first ball to the open court, 4 of 6

RUN IT Player serves wide (deuce or ad, their pick); coach returns to the middle; player must take the next ball into the open court. Run 6 sequences.

PASS BAR 4 of 6 sequences: the serve lands in the wide third, the +1 ball lands in the open half.

2 Run a 3-shot pattern the coach names, twice

RUN IT Coach names a pattern — 'deep cross, deep cross, short angle', or 'backhand line, forehand cross, come in' — and the player runs it live against coach feeds.

PASS BAR The named pattern executed correctly twice, in any reasonable number of tries.

3 Say out loud what you are trying to do before the point starts

RUN IT Before 4 practice points, coach asks: what's the plan? Player states one concrete intention.

PASS BAR 4 of 4 points have a real, specific plan — 'serve wide, attack the backhand'. 'Try to win' is not a plan.

4 DEFENSE & TRANSITION

1 Slice or lob to reset from behind the baseline, 4 of 6

RUN IT Coach attacks 6 balls that push the player well behind the baseline; the player must reset with a deep slice or lob.

PASS BAR 4 of 6 resets land past the service line, high enough that the coach cannot attack the next ball.

2 Approach-and-volley combination won 4 of 6

RUN IT Coach feeds short; player approaches and plays out the point against genuine (but fair) passing attempts. 6 points.

PASS BAR Win 4 of 6 points at the net.

3 Get back to neutral after being pushed into the back fence

RUN IT Coach drives the player toward the fence with two heavy deep balls, then continues the rally. Run 3 rallies.

PASS BAR On 2 of 3, the player escapes the fence, works forward, and reaches a neutral baseline position within three shots.

5 COMPETITION

PROMOTION TEST

1 Play a complete set with a tiebreak, fully self-officiated

RUN IT A full set against a peer (play a tiebreak at the end regardless of score, to test the procedure), coach outside the fence.

PASS BAR The set completes with correct tiebreak procedure — serve rotation, change of ends, and score all handled by the players.

2 Play a USTA match or a club tournament

RUN IT Any USTA junior event, UTR event, or official club tournament. The director verifies the result online.

PASS BAR Complete one match. This is the invitation trigger: playing it means the player wants more.

3 Have a UTR

RUN IT The director looks the player up on UTR after their event.

PASS BAR A UTR profile exists with at least one result. The number itself does not matter at all.

WHEN STRING 5 IS CLEARED

Earns the **High Performance invitation**. Yellow 5 is the only door into HP, and it is the Director's call.

COACH NOTES — who is close, who has a retest waiting

COACH	DATE		CLASS / GROUP		COURT	
PLAYER NAME	BALL COLOR circle one	STRING circle one	TESTS PASSED tick each	STRING EARNED	NOTES / WHAT TO RETEST NEXT MONTH	
1	R O G Y	1 2 3 4 5	1 2 3			
2	R O G Y	1 2 3 4 5	1 2 3			
3	R O G Y	1 2 3 4 5	1 2 3			
4	R O G Y	1 2 3 4 5	1 2 3			
5	R O G Y	1 2 3 4 5	1 2 3			
6	R O G Y	1 2 3 4 5	1 2 3			
7	R O G Y	1 2 3 4 5	1 2 3			
8	R O G Y	1 2 3 4 5	1 2 3			
9	R O G Y	1 2 3 4 5	1 2 3			
10	R O G Y	1 2 3 4 5	1 2 3			
11	R O G Y	1 2 3 4 5	1 2 3			
12	R O G Y	1 2 3 4 5	1 2 3			
13	R O G Y	1 2 3 4 5	1 2 3			
14	R O G Y	1 2 3 4 5	1 2 3			

PROMOTIONS TODAY — string 5 cleared, moving up a ball color

WHEN YOU'RE DONE

1. Tie the band on every earned racquet, at the net, name said out loud.

2. Hand this sheet to Darrin — results go into ClubMode and the family sees it that night.

3. Partial passes bank. Only what's blank gets retested next month.